Grade 10 November Examination 2025

UNSEEN POETRY

***Last Post* (2009)**
by Carol Ann Duffy

In all my dreams, before my helpless sight,
He plunges at me, guttering, choking, drowning.
If poetry could tell it backwards, true, begin
that moment shrapnel scythed you to the stinking mud…
but you get up, amazed, watch bled bad blood
run upwards from the slime into its wounds;
see lines and lines of British boys rewind
back to their trenches, kiss the photographs from home –
mothers, sweethearts, sisters, younger brothers
not entering the story now
to die and die and die.
Dulce – No – Decorum – No – Pro patria mori.
You walk away.
You walk away; drop your gun (fixed bayonet)
like all your mates do too –
Harry, Tommy, Wilfred, Edward, Bert –
and light a cigarette.
There's coffee in the square,
warm French bread
and all those thousands dead
are shaking dried mud from their hair
and queuing up for home. Freshly alive,
a lad plays Tipperary to the crowd, released
from History; the glistening, healthy horses fit for heroes, kings.
You lean against a wall,
your several million lives still possible
and crammed with love, work, children, talent, English beer, good food.
You see the poet tuck away his pocket-book and smile.
If poetry could truly tell it backwards,
then it would.

Level 2 and 4: Comprehension and Analysis

2.1. Suggest how the reference to the lines from *Dulce et Decorum est* (lines 1 and 2) of Duffy's poem positions us to understand the speaker's position on war. (3)

Dulce et Decorum est is a strongly anti-war poem that shows the true horror that soldiers experienced. This then reveals Duffy's perspective to be the same, that war is not honourable, but a tragedy. These specific lines reveal the horror suffered by a soldier and thus make this connection even more strongly.

Level 2, 4 and 6: Comprehension, Analysis and Evaluation

2.2. "but you get up, amazed, watch bled bad blood
run upwards from the slime into its wounds;" (lines 5-6)

Identify the figures of speech used in these lines and comment on their effectiveness in conveying the speaker's tone and intention. (4)

The alliteration of the 'b' in "bled bad blood' creates a harshness in sound that connects to the image of terrible wounds bleeding, this links to the speaker's critical tone, critical of a war that caused such suffering and death. The blood is personified as it runs upwards and back into the wounds – repairing, healing, but the use of "slime" still emphasises the awful conditions and horror experienced by the young men.

Level 2: Comprehension

2.3. What power do you think the speaker wishes a poet could have? (1)

The power to rewrite history differently, instead of having to record the awful nature of war in writing.

Dulce et Decorum est by Wilfred Owen

Bent double, like old beggars under sacks,
Knock-kneed, coughing like hags, we cursed through sludge,
Till on the haunting flares we turned our backs,
And towards our distant rest began to trudge.
Men marched asleep. Many had lost their boots,
But limped on, blood-shod. All went lame; all blind;
Drunk with fatigue; deaf even to the hoots
Of gas-shells dropping softly behind.

Gas! GAS! Quick, boys!—An ecstasy of fumbling
Fitting the clumsy helmets just in time,
But someone still was yelling out and stumbling
And flound'ring like a man in fire or lime.—
Dim through the misty panes and thick green light,
As under a green sea, I saw him drowning.

In all my dreams before my helpless sight,
He plunges at me, guttering, choking, drowning.

If in some smothering dreams, you too could pace
Behind the wagon that we flung him in,
And watch the white eyes writhing in his face,
His hanging face, like a devil's sick of sin;
If you could hear, at every jolt, the blood
Come gargling from the froth-corrupted lungs,
Obscene as cancer, bitter as the cud
Of vile, incurable sores on innocent tongues,—
My friend, you would not tell with such high zest
To children ardent for some desperate glory,
The old Lie: *Dulce et decorum est*
Pro patria mori.

Level 4: Analysis

2.4. Owen declares the saying "Dulce et decorum est Pro patria mori" to be an "old Lie". How does Duffy in her poem *Last Post* subvert this saying? (2)

Duffy uses punctuation and the interjection of "no" to subvert this saying. The line, "Dulce – No – Decorum – No – Pro patria mori" breaks up the saying that originally means it is sweet and fitting to die for one's country, declaring twice that "no" it is not.

Level 4 and 6: Analysis and Evaluation

2.5. Both *Dulce et Decorum Est* and *Last Post* highlight the tragedy of the wasted youth in war. Analyse the imagery and diction in each poem and decide which poem you feel conveys this sense of loss most effectively. Refer closely to both poems in your answer. (5)

Students may choose either poem. Dulce et Decorum Est uses graphic detail of the horror of war and the suffering of the men and reminds us that they are just "children ardent for some desperate glory". These young men are shown to be like "beggars" and "hags", aged and burdened by what they have to face. Last Post is poignant in its desire to turn back time and bring these young men back, "freshly alive" so that the "several million lives" lost will still be possible and will be "crammed with love, work, children, talent, English beer, good food." The simple, joyful aspects of life that these young men had waiting for them before the war.

15 marks